

TOEFL iBT – FULL SIMULATED TEST

(Complete Practice Version – No Abridgements)

READING SECTION

(3 passages – 36 questions – 54–72 minutes)

Reading Passage 1

Oceanic Carbon Sequestration and Seagrass Meadows

Seagrass meadows, found in shallow coastal waters worldwide, play a critical but often underappreciated role in the global carbon cycle. Through photosynthesis, seagrasses fix carbon and deposit a portion of it in sediments beneath the meadows, a process known as “blue carbon” sequestration. Unlike terrestrial ecosystems, the carbon stored in seagrass sediments can remain buried for centuries under anoxic conditions, making these habitats significant long-term carbon sinks.

Seagrass ecosystems provide multiple co-benefits beyond carbon storage. They stabilize sediments, reduce coastal erosion, and serve as nurseries for fish and invertebrates, supporting fisheries. Additionally, seagrasses improve water quality by trapping particles and uptaking excess nutrients. Unfortunately, seagrass meadows are declining globally due to coastal development, eutrophication, physical damage from boats, and climate change. Loss of seagrass not only diminishes biodiversity and fishery support but also releases stored carbon back into the water column and atmosphere, exacerbating greenhouse gas concentrations.

Estimating the carbon sequestration potential of seagrass meadows involves measuring biomass production, sediment accumulation rates, and sediment organic carbon content. Researchers use a combination of methods: direct core sampling to assess sediment carbon stocks, remote sensing to map meadow extent, and modeling to predict future changes under different management scenarios. Challenges include variability in species composition, hydrodynamic conditions, and anthropogenic pressures across sites. Therefore, extrapolating sequestration rates from local studies to regional or global scales carries uncertainty.

Policy interest in blue carbon has increased as nations seek nature-based solutions to mitigate climate change. Incorporating seagrass protection and restoration into coastal management can contribute to national greenhouse gas inventories and potentially generate credits under carbon offset schemes. However, accounting frameworks must carefully consider permanence, leakage (e.g., displacement of damaging activities), and measurement reliability. Effective policies combine protection, restoration, and pollution control, alongside stakeholder engagement and long-term monitoring.

Questions 1–12

1. The term “blue carbon” in the passage refers to:
A. carbon in atmospheric CO₂ above oceans
B. carbon sequestered in marine ecosystems
C. carbon emissions from ships
D. carbon in terrestrial forests adjacent to coasts

2. Why is carbon stored in seagrass sediments particularly long-lasting? A. Because of low temperatures B. Because sediments are often anoxic C. Because of continuous plant growth D. Because of human protection efforts
3. Besides carbon sequestration, which is NOT listed as a benefit of seagrass meadows? A. Stabilizing sediments B. Serving as fish nurseries C. Increasing storm frequency D. Improving water quality
4. What is a major cause of seagrass decline mentioned? A. Overfishing only B. Coastal development and eutrophication C. Increased seagrass diseases D. Natural predators
5. Which method is NOT mentioned for estimating sequestration? A. Core sampling B. Remote sensing C. Modeling D. Genetic sequencing
6. Why is extrapolating sequestration rates to larger scales problematic? A. Lack of interest from policymakers B. Variability across sites C. Too many seagrass species globally D. High economic costs
7. How might seagrass restoration be used in climate policy? A. As an energy source B. To generate carbon offset credits C. To increase shipping lanes D. To decrease fishing yields
8. What does “leakage” refer to in this context? A. Oil spills damaging seagrass B. Displacement of damaging activities C. Water seeping from sediments D. Gas escaping from the ocean
9. Effective policies should combine all EXCEPT: A. Protection B. Restoration C. Pollution control D. Increasing coastal development
10. Which measurement assesses sediment organic carbon? A. Biomass production rate B. Sediment core analysis C. Remote sensing imagery D. Hydrodynamic modeling
11. The phrase “carrying uncertainty” in paragraph three mainly refers to: A. Unreliable lab equipment B. Difficulty in scaling local data accurately C. Policy disagreements D. Weather unpredictability
12. According to the passage, seagrass loss can lead to: A. Permanent reduction in ocean salinity B. Release of stored carbon back to the atmosphere C. Immediate increase in sea levels D. Decrease in ocean temperatures

Reading Passage 2

The Psychology of Habit Formation

Habits are behaviors performed automatically in response to contextual cues, minimizing cognitive effort. Psychological research conceptualizes habit formation as the gradual shift from goal-directed actions to stimulus-driven behavior. Reinforcement learning frameworks explain how repetition and reward associations strengthen stimulus–response links, making behaviors more automatic.

Key elements influencing habit formation include cue consistency, the reward schedule, and context stability. Consistent cues strengthen associations; variable rewards can make behavior more persistent due to unpredictability. Context stability—performing the behavior in the same setting—also supports habit consolidation, as environmental cues become reliable triggers.

Interventions to change habits focus on altering cues, modifying rewards, and restructuring context. For example, placing healthy snacks at eye level changes the cue environment; using commitment devices alters reward structures; and moving workouts to a regular time and location leverages context stability. Research shows that forming a new habit typically requires a median of 66 days, though the range varies widely depending on behavior complexity and individual differences.

Habit research has practical applications in health, education, and organizational settings. In health, interventions aim to replace unhealthy behaviors with healthier alternatives; in education, routines can scaffold study habits; and in workplaces, designing environments that cue productive behaviors can increase efficiency. However, ethical considerations arise when habit-forming techniques are used to manipulate consumer behavior or exploit vulnerabilities.

Questions 13–24

13. According to the passage, habits primarily reduce:
 - A. social interactions
 - B. cognitive effort
 - C. physical activity
 - D. financial costs
14. What framework explains habit strengthening via repetition and reward?
 - A. Cognitive dissonance
 - B. Reinforcement learning
 - C. Psychoanalytic theory
 - D. Social learning
15. Which factor makes a behavior more persistent?
 - A. Consistent cues only
 - B. Variable rewards
 - C. Changing context
 - D. Lack of repetition
16. What supports habit consolidation?
 - A. Variable context
 - B. Performing behavior in the same setting
 - C. Absence of rewards
 - D. Random timing
17. Which is an example of altering cues?
 - A. Using commitment devices
 - B. Placing healthy snacks at eye level
 - C. Moving workouts to different locations
 - D. Removing all rewards
18. What is the median number of days to form a new habit, per the passage?
 - A. 21 days
 - B. 30 days
 - C. 66 days
 - D. 100 days
19. Habit research can be applied in all areas EXCEPT:
 - A. Health
 - B. Education
 - C. Astronomy
 - D. Organizational settings
20. What ethical concern is mentioned?
 - A. Lack of effectiveness
 - B. Manipulation of consumer behavior
 - C. High costs of interventions
 - D. Inaccurate measurements
21. Which term describes behaviors that become automatic in response to cues?
 - A. Goal-directed actions
 - B. Stimulus-driven behavior
 - C. Conscious planning

- D. Random actions
22. Which practice helps modify reward structures?
- A. Changing location
 - B. Commitment devices
 - C. Removing cues
 - D. Avoiding rewards
23. Why does variability in reward help persistence?
- A. Because it increases predictability
 - B. Because unpredictability strengthens behavior
 - C. Because it reduces motivation
 - D. Because it simplifies the task
24. Which of the following is NOT cited as a key element influencing habits?
- A. Cue consistency
 - B. Reward schedule
 - C. Context stability
 - D. Genetic predisposition

Reading Passage 3

Renewable Grid Integration: Storage and Demand Response

The increasing penetration of variable renewable energy sources, such as wind and solar, poses operational challenges for electrical grids originally designed for predictable, dispatchable generators. Two strategies to integrate renewables are energy storage systems and demand response programs. Storage can absorb excess generation during peaks and supply power during lulls, while demand response shifts consumption patterns to better match generation.

Various storage technologies exist: pumped hydro, lithium-ion batteries, flow batteries, and emerging options like compressed-air energy storage. Each has trade-offs in terms of cost, efficiency, duration, and geographical constraints. Pumped hydro is cost-effective for large-scale, long-duration storage but requires suitable topography. Batteries offer rapid response and modular deployment but are relatively expensive for bulk, long-duration needs.

Demand response involves adjusting consumer demand through price signals, incentives, or direct load control. Time-of-use tariffs and automated load management can encourage consumers to shift consumption away from peak periods. Combining storage with demand response increases system flexibility and can reduce the need for expensive peaking plants.

Integrating storage and demand-side measures also raises questions about market design and regulatory frameworks. For instance, ensuring that storage operators receive appropriate compensation for services like frequency regulation and capacity provision is essential. Additionally, equitable access to demand response programs should be considered, as low-income households may be less able to modify consumption patterns or invest in enabling technologies. Policymakers must design incentives to ensure broad participation without unfairly burdening vulnerable populations.

Modeling studies suggest that a mix of storage and demand response can significantly reduce curtailment of renewable generation and lower overall system costs under high renewable penetration scenarios. However, the optimal mix depends on local factors such as resource variability, load characteristics, and transmission infrastructure. Continued innovation in storage materials and control algorithms will further influence the cost-effectiveness of different strategies.

Questions 25–36

25. What problem does increasing renewable penetration create for grids?
- A. Increased fuel costs
 - B. Operational challenges due to variability
 - C. Decreased efficiency of thermal plants
 - D. Reduced consumer demand
26. Which storage option is noted as cost-effective for long-duration, large-scale needs?
- A. Lithium-ion batteries
 - B. Pumped hydro
 - C. Flow batteries
 - D. Compressed-air storage
27. Why might batteries be less suitable for bulk long-duration storage?
- A. Because they are slow to respond
 - B. Because they are relatively expensive for bulk, long-duration needs
 - C. Because they need special topography
 - D. Because they are not modular
28. What is an example of demand response?
- A. Building more power plants
 - B. Time-of-use tariffs
 - C. Increasing base load
 - D. Using fossil fuels
29. Combining storage with demand response can reduce the need for:
- A. Renewable generation
 - B. Peaking plants
 - C. Transmission upgrades
 - D. Consumer participation
30. What market issue must be addressed for storage operators?
- A. Training requirements
 - B. Compensation for services like frequency regulation
 - C. Limiting competition
 - D. Reducing storage sizes
31. Why must equitable access to demand response be considered?
- A. Because high-income households refuse to participate
 - B. Because low-income households may lack ability to modify consumption
 - C. Because demand response is ineffective
 - D. Because technology is inexpensive
32. What determines the optimal mix of storage and demand response?
- A. Universal global standards
 - B. Local factors like resource variability and transmission
 - C. Only technological innovation
 - D. Political ideology
33. Modeling studies suggest mixing storage and demand response leads to:
- A. Increased curtailment
 - B. Reduced curtailment and lower system costs
 - C. Higher overall costs
 - D. Less renewable generation
34. Which future developments will influence cost-effectiveness?
- A. Changes in consumer tastes
 - B. Innovations in storage materials and control algorithms
 - C. Decreasing electricity demand
 - D. More fossil fuel subsidies

35. Demand response typically shifts consumption by:
- A. Increasing production
 - B. Adjusting consumer demand through price signals or incentives
 - C. Building more storage
 - D. Reducing renewable generation
36. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as a storage technology?
- A. Pumped hydro
 - B. Sodium-sulfur batteries
 - C. Flow batteries
 - D. Compressed-air energy storage
-

LISTENING SECTION

(Play each recording only once)

Conversation 1 – Dormitory Maintenance Request

Questions 37–41

- 37. What is the problem Emma reports?
- 38. What did she try to fix it?
- 39. When will maintenance come?
- 40. Will they enter if she is not present?
- 41. What does Liam ask Emma to ensure in the hallway?

Conversation 2 – Registrar: Course Enrollment

Questions 42–46

- 42. Which course does Omar want to enroll in?
- 43. Why is the course currently unavailable?
- 44. What does Sofia need to know about Omar's academic history?
- 45. How long will Omar have to register if a spot opens?
- 46. Who gets priority for enrollment?

Lecture 1 – Cognitive Load Theory

Questions 47–52

- 47. What does cognitive load refer to?
- 48. Name the three types of cognitive load mentioned.
- 49. What is an example of extraneous load?
- 50. How can teachers manage intrinsic load?
- 51. What is the split-attention effect?
- 52. Give one classroom tip to reduce extraneous load.

Lecture 2 – Plate Tectonics and Mountain Building

Questions 53–58

- 53. What are the three plate boundary types listed?
- 54. Which type of boundary is associated with mountain building via continental collision?
- 55. What geological feature forms at subduction zones?
- 56. What does isostasy explain?
- 57. Over what timescale do these processes occur?
- 58. Name one method used to date geological events mentioned.

Lecture 3 – Behavioral Economics: Present Bias

Questions 59–64

- 59. What is present bias?
 - 60. Give one implication of present bias.
 - 61. Name one commitment device example.
 - 62. What model describes declining preference for immediacy?
 - 63. What types of studies provide evidence?
 - 64. How do commitment devices affect behavior?
-

SPEAKING SECTION

Task 1 – Independent

Preparation time: 15 seconds Response time: 45 seconds

Some people prefer to study alone while others prefer to study in groups. Which do you prefer and why? Give specific reasons and examples to support your answer.

Task 2 – Integrated (Campus Situation)

Read the announcement (45 seconds):

The university library will extend opening hours during exam weeks to give students more study time. The extended hours will run from 8 a.m. to 2 a.m. for two weeks.

Then listen to the conversation once.

Preparation time: 30 seconds Response time: 60 seconds

The woman/man expresses his/her opinion about the announcement. State the opinion and explain the reasons he/she gives.

Task 3 – Integrated (Reading + Lecture)

Read the passage (45 seconds):

Researchers propose a new conservation policy that restricts motorboats in designated bay areas to protect seagrass meadows. The policy argues boats damage seagrass and increase sediment disturbance, harming marine habitats.

Then listen to the lecture once.

Preparation time: 30 seconds Response time: 60 seconds

Explain how the points made by the professor cast doubt on the proposal in the reading passage.

Task 4 – Integrated Academic Lecture

Listen to a short academic lecture once and summarize the main points and important examples.

WRITING SECTION

Integrated Writing – 20 minutes

(Read a passage → Listen to a lecture that opposes it → Write how the lecture challenges the reading)

Independent Writing – 30 minutes

Do you agree or disagree with the following statement?

“It is more important for students to study history and literature than it is for them to study science and mathematics.”

Use specific reasons and examples to support your opinion.
